

EDUCATIONPLUS

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Sanil Raj Johnson

In February 2025, members of a peer-review team of the National Assessment and Accreditation Council (NAAC), including its chairman, were arrested by the CBI for allegedly accepting bribes to grant a top ‘A++’ grade to an institution. If accreditation, the very system meant to certify quality, can be compromised, then what are we truly measuring: institutional merit or institutional performance in staging merit?

What was once a quality assurance measure has, over time, developed into a kind of industry. Institutions now build dedicated teams – sometimes only for accreditation cycles – whose main job is to prepare for inspections, carefully organising activities to meet expected standards. Whether programmes are truly meaningful becomes less important. What matters is whether they can be documented, formatted, and presented convincingly. This process favours those who excel at presenting well over those who maintain genuine academic depth.

Too much documentation

At the heart of this transformation is the overwhelming dominance of documentation. The NAAC framework, with its multiple criteria – curriculum, teaching-learning, research, infrastructure, go-



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Accreditation or academic illusion?

Nearly two decades into the accreditation and ranking systems for higher education, questions about their real impact continue

vernance, and institutional values – requires extensive supporting documents. Faculty members are increasingly burdened with preparing reports, uploading evidence, and maintaining records. A well-documented activity becomes more valid than a meaningful but undocumented academic endeavour. This is in contrast to practices at institutions like the University of Michigan, the U.S., where the focus is on what students have learned, not on how much institutions can project.

The issue worsens when accreditation influences rankings like those in the National Institutional Ranking Framework

(NIRF), which depend heavily upon data provided by institutions themselves. Although verification systems exist, the recent scandal highlights their loopholes. If peer review can be manipulated, the trustworthiness of the entire ranking system is compromised.

Institutions, in turn, use accreditation and rankings as marketing tools by prominently showcasing grades and positions to attract students. In this process, the line between authentic academic quality and strategic self-presentation becomes increasingly blurred.

International systems offer an entirely different

approach. In the U.K., universities are assessed by the Quality Assurance Agency for Higher Education (QAA), which whether institutional activities genuinely promote student learning. Similarly, in Australia, the Tertiary Education Quality and Standards Agency (TEQSA) uses a risk-based approach.

Impact on faculty

As teachers become more engaged in documentation and compliance, their interaction with students declines. Ongoing assessment, mentoring, and intellectual exchange are overshadowed by administrative tasks. This distortion is especially severe in

India’s uneven educational landscape. Rural and under-resourced institutions, lacking basic infrastructure, are assessed using the same criteria as well-funded urban counterparts. Accreditation, instead of reducing inequality, often worsens it by favouring visibility and resources over context and effort.

Nearly two decades into operating accreditation and ranking systems, it is worth questioning their real impact. Has academic quality truly improved? Could students experience meaningful learning? Or have institutions just become better at self-promotion? The National Education Policy (NEP) 2020

proposes a restructured accreditation framework that emphasises transparency, technology, and continuous evaluation. While these reforms are mandatory, they will fail if they simply digitise an existing over-bureaucratised system.

Accreditation must return to its core purpose: improving educational quality. This requires a clear shift from focusing on documentation to emphasising results, from valuing performance to emphasising substance, and from mere compliance to promoting creativity. Faculty should be liberated from excessive bureaucratic burdens and reconnected with their primary role as educators. Evaluation must become sensitive to context, acknowledging institutional differences along with providing fair and supportive measures.

Last year’s scandal exposes a deeper systemic problem. When achievements can be staged, recorded, and even bought, accreditation becomes a false facade. For Indian higher education to regain its credibility, it must dismantle this illusion and create a system rooted in honesty, trust, and genuine learning.

Views expressed are personal

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SCHOLARSHIPS

Kotak Kanya Scholarship

An initiative of Kotak Mahindra Group companies and Kotak Education Foundation.
Eligibility: Girl students across India who have scored 75% or more in Class 12 and secured admission to the first year of a and Engineering, MBBS, Architecture, Design, Integrated LLB, or other professional degree programme at an NIRF/NAAC-accredited institute and has an annual family income not exceeding ₹6,00,000.
Rewards: 1.5 lakh a year, till completion of degree.
Application: Online
Deadline: August 20
www.b4s.in/edge/KKGS5

National Means-cum-Merit Scholarship

Offered by the Department of School Education and Literacy, Union Ministry of Education
Eligibility: Open to Indian

students enrolled in class 9 in a government or government-aided, and local body school, who have secured at least 60% marks in class 8 (55% for SC/ST students) and have an annual family income below ₹3,50,000.
Rewards: ₹12,000 per annum.
Application: Online
Deadline: August 31
www.b4s.in/edge/NMSS55

MARIHE Research Erasmus Mundus Full Scholarship

Offered by the Erasmus+ Programme of the European Union (EU).
Eligibility: Students with a three-year university degree who demonstrate a strong motivation and interest to learn and work in research and innovation in higher education and show proof of English proficiency.
Rewards: €1400
Application: Online
Deadline: September 21
www.b4s.in/edge/MARI2

Courtesy: Buddy4study.com

Award

Three students of Azim Premji University’s B.Sc. (Honours) in Environmental Science and Sustainability programme – Anuja Krishna, Shivaani Arunprasad, and Vanya Hegde – have been selected as EnviroChamp Fellows 2026, part of a

10-member cohort chosen through a rigorous and independent selection process by the Avery Dennison Foundation, the U.S., in partnership with the Institute of International Education (IIE). The aim is to empower young women become leaders in environmental sustainability.



OFF THE EDGE

Nandini Raman
I completed Class 12 (Computer Science and Maths) but want to be a CA. I did not score well in the board exams. How can I achieve my goal? Shilo

Dear Shilo,
The Institute of Chartered Accountants of India (ICAI) does not have a minimum percentage requirement to register for the CA Foundation. If you have passed, you are eligible.

Your Computer Science and Maths background gives you an advantage in Paper 3 (Quantitative Aptitude), which covers Maths, Logical Reasoning and Statistics. Your biggest challenge will be bridging the Commerce gap. Focus first on the fundamentals of Accounting: Double Entry System, Journal Entries, Ledgers and Trial Balance. Don’t get intimidated by Accounting or Business Laws; take them one step at a time.

Follow the 50/10 Rule: Study with complete focus for 50 minutes, followed by a 10-minute break. Practise active recall by summarising concepts or solving problems. Keep your phone away and minimise distractions.

The CA Foundation is held in January, May/June and September. Pick the slot that gives you enough time to build a strong foundation and prepare confidently.

Remember, CA rewards discipline, persistence, and logical thinking.

I am a CA Finalist. I have cleared the earlier exams with AIRs in first attempt and am currently undergoing articleship. I also completed my graduation this year. But I feel this is not sufficient to get a good placement.

Eyes on the goal

Uncertain about your career options? Low on self-confidence? This column may help

Would a PG or PGDM be a good option? Karthik

Dear Karthik,
A first attempt CA with an AIR places you among the very best. Before committing time and money to another degree, recognise the value of your profile. Top consulting firms, investment banks, and private equity and venture capital firms actively recruit CA rank holders.

If your ambition is a top leadership or strategy role, remember that brand value matters. A regular M.Com/M.Sc. Finance adds little to your profile but an MBA/PGDM from the IIMs at Ahmedabad, Bengaluru, or Kolkata, or ISB or XLRI can significantly expand your career opportunities.

Complete your CA Final with an AIR, enter the ICAI rank-holder placement pool, and gain corporate experience. This will help you identify your interests while earning a premium salary.

If you aspire to global leadership or PE/VC, pursue a top-tier MBA after gaining work experience.

For now, focus on the CA Final rather than splintering your attention with preparing for MBA entrance exams.

My son is in the first year of B.Com Professional Accounting. He wants to change to a career in aviation and become a pilot. How can he do this? Jagan

Dear Jagan,
To obtain a Commercial Pilot Licence (CPL), he must have completed Class 12 with Physics and Maths. Since he has not done Physics, he must clear it

through the National Institute of Open Schooling (NIOS), which is recognised by the DGCA.

But first, have him undergo a DGCA-approved Class 2 Medical Examination to confirm that he meets the physical fitness standards. The doctor will also initiate his Permanent Medical Record (PMR).

Then he can take the NIOS Physics Class 12 exams and, once the results are available, register on the eGCA portal to obtain the Computer Number, which is required for all DGCA examinations.

Next, he must clear the DGCA theory papers in Air Navigation, Aviation Meteorology, Air Regulations, Technical General/Specific and RTRA (Radio Telephony) and also upgrade to a Class 1 Medical Certificate before receiving the CPL.

He can then choose between two training paths. The Conventional Flying Training Organisation (FTO) route requires 200 flying hours, costs around ₹45–60 lakhs, takes between 1.5 and years, and does not guarantee a job.

The Airline Cadet Pilot Programme is more structured, with training completed in 15–21 months. It costs around ₹90 lakhs to ₹1.2 crores, includes end-to-end training and offers a Letter of Intent from an airline, leading to employment as a First Officer subject to successful completion of the programme.

I am in Class 12 and wish to pursue Architecture. I have decided to appear only for the NATA and not other competitive exams. Is this a suitable career for women? How can I get

a position in a reputable firm? Harsika

Dear Harshika,
This is a completely valid and efficient path. The Council of Architecture (CoA) allows hundreds of reputed state universities, private design schools, and institutions such as CEPT University and Sir J.J. College of Architecture to admit students based on NATA scores.

Of course, architecture is suitable for women, and many leading architecture schools have equal or even higher female enrolment than male.

Architecture is far more than construction sites. It includes conceptual design, Building Information Modelling (BIM), urban planning, landscape architecture, sustainability, and interior design. Many women successfully lead design firms, head architectural divisions in large companies, and specialise in computational design and research.

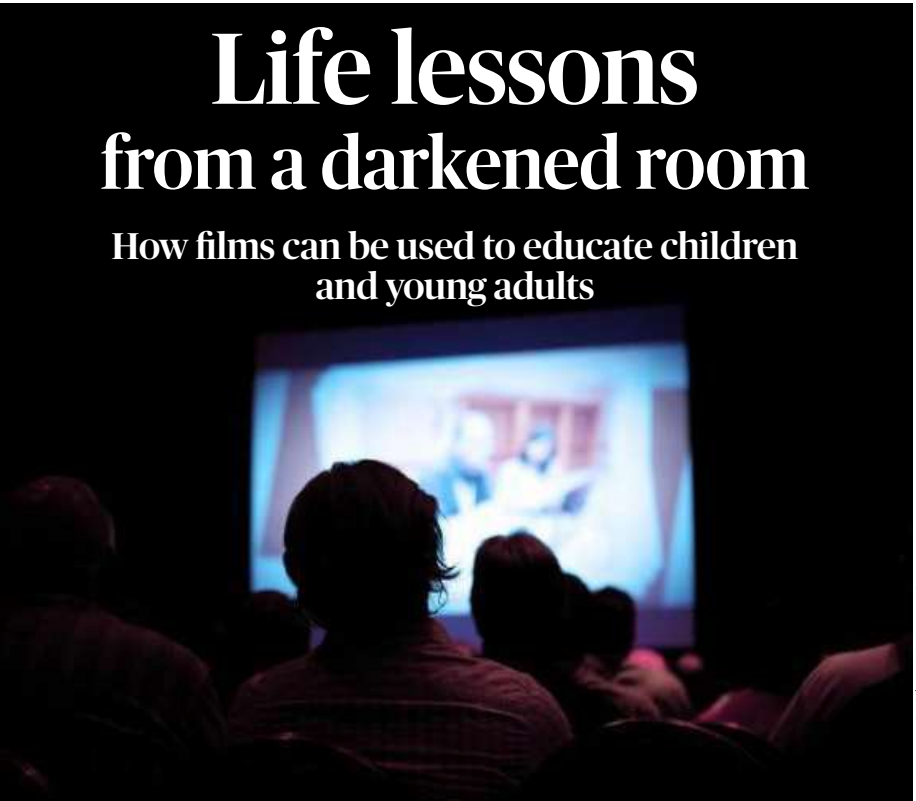
The CoA also enforces workplace guidelines that promote gender parity, safety and professional standards.

While architecture involves long hours, deadlines, and coordination with multiple teams, it rewards creativity, problem-solving, spatial thinking and communication.

One major advantage is that architecture firms recruit primarily on merit, design thinking, and the strength of your portfolio, rather than written tests or college percentages.

Disclaimer: This column is merely a guiding voice and provides advice and suggestions on education and careers.

The writer is a practising counsellor and a trainer. Send your questions to eduplus.thehindu@gmail.com with the subject line Off the Edge



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Life lessons from a darkened room

How films can be used to educate children and young adults

Syed Sultan Ahmed

I was sitting in a cinema hall last year, watching a film with a group of 15 year olds. The story followed a boy going about his morning routine, entirely alone at home, quietly trying to brighten his own day. No dialogue for the first three minutes. Just images. Afterwards, a young girl said, “I never knew how to talk about what happens at home. But, watching this, I felt someone understood.” That sentence stayed with me.

We live in an age of information overload, yet our classrooms are quiet about the subjects that matter most: mental health, grief, bullying, identity, failure... The topics that shape who a child becomes are precisely the ones we are most reluctant to address directly. We talk around them. We distribute pamphlets. We invite counsellors for a 40-minute session once a year. Then we wonder why students don’t engage.

The data tells a sharper story. In a survey of 1,000 adolescents across eight In-

dian cities, nearly 38% reported social anxiety as their most prevalent daily struggle and 45% said their biggest burden was the communication gap with their own parents. Over a third exhibited low self-confidence. These are not abstract problems. They are sitting in the classrooms right now.

Narrative transportation

This is where cinema can help. Films reach where instruction cannot. Research shows that eight year olds retain nearly 90% of what they see in a film six weeks after viewing it. The number is the same three months later. More striking, a child’s attitude toward a social value can be measurably shifted by a single exposure to a well-crafted film. Not a term of lessons. Not a chapter. One film.

What cinema does, at its best, is create what researchers call narrative transportation or the state where a viewer is so immersed in a story that the emotional experience becomes real. When a child watches a character navi-

gate peer pressure, sit with the shame of a lie, or find the courage to speak about something painful at home, they are not merely observing. They are rehearsing and processing, at a safe distance, the situations their own lives will eventually demand from them.

Beyond the screening

This safe distance is not avoidance; it is access. For adolescents navigating identity, fear of failure, and the acute anxiety of being misunderstood, the distance that fiction provides is often the only door through which honest conversation becomes possible. But – and this is critical – film alone is not enough. Studies consistently show that the deeper impact comes from what happens in the room before and after the screening. Guided discussion. Structured reflection. The questions a good facilitator asks. When film is paired with dialogue and internalisation activities, students show significant improvements in self-esteem, emotional stability, social intelligence, and general

well-being. The students who experience structured film-based learning diverge sharply from those who do not.

One teacher put it simply. “I would never have known my student was sensitive and mature. I only saw him as naughty and not so bright. The session helped me understand him better.” That shift in how a teacher sees a child may be the most underestimated outcome of all.

This is equally true beyond school. At the college level – where we expect young adults to navigate ethics, relationships, ambiguity, and systemic complexity – film remains a profoundly underused pedagogical tool. A film about a whistleblower teaches corporate responsibility better than a case study. A story about a first-generation student navigating class and aspiration teaches social inequality better than a lecture. Universities globally are beginning to embed film analysis into Medicine, Law, and Public Policy for precisely this reason.

There is a line from the research that I keep returning to: film used in a structured way becomes a powerful means of preparing children for life, not just for exams. That distinction, life versus exams, is everything. We have spent decades optimising our schools for one and neglecting the other. The result is students who can solve for x but cannot navigate a difficult conversation. Who can write a précis but cannot sit with someone else’s pain.

The darkened room of a cinema hall, it turns out, may be one of the brightest spaces a school can build. The question is not whether we can afford to bring films into our classrooms. It is whether we can afford not to.

The writer is Founder and Chief Learner, LXL Ideas, and Chairperson, The Association of International Schools of India (TAISI)

Priya Adwani

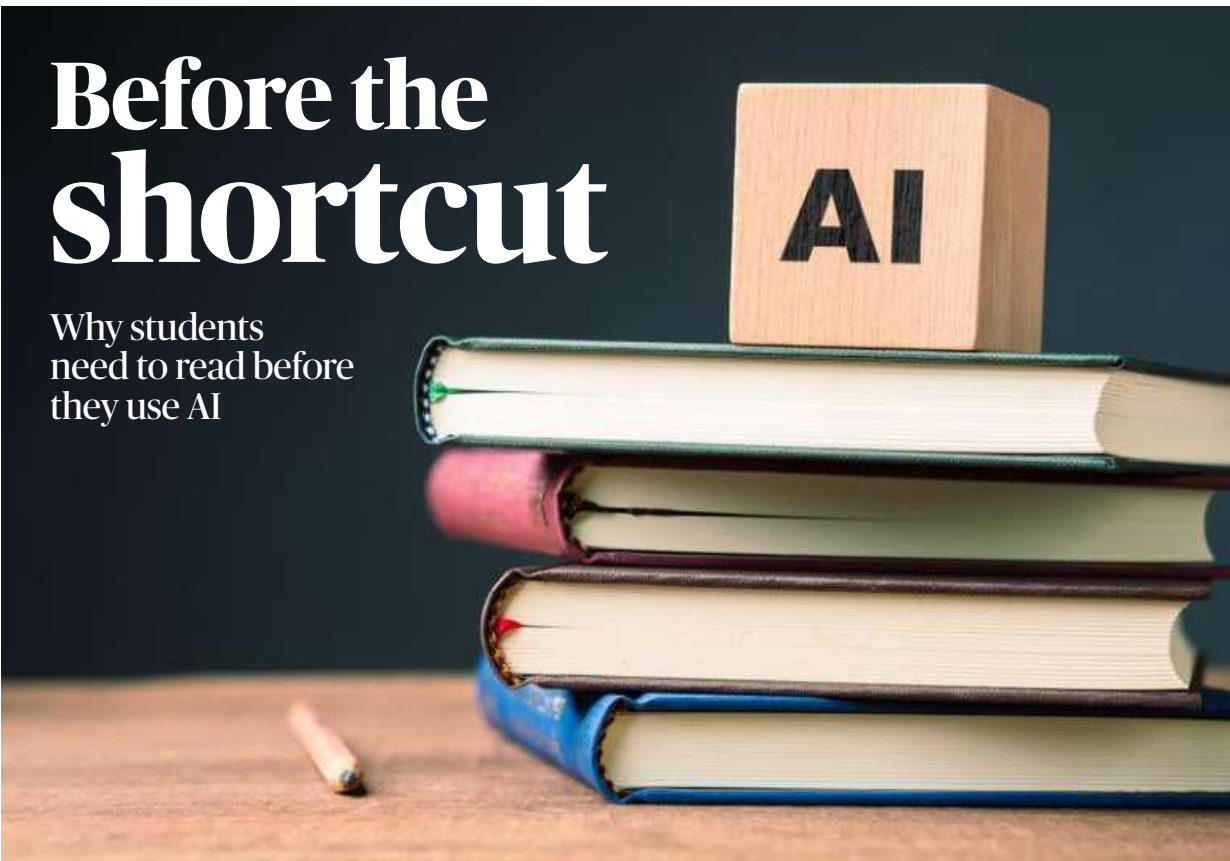
When 13-year-old Riya was assigned a short story to read as part of an assignment, she photographed the page, fed it to an AI, read the summary in 40 seconds, wrote her paragraph, and went to bed. She never read the story. She would tell you, honestly, that she did not need to. She is right. But that is exactly the problem.

The companies building AI tools for education are not lying when they say their products open up learning. A child in a village with no books, no coaching centre, no college-educated parent can now have a difficult concept explained at midnight with more patience than any teacher exhausted by 40 students can manage. That matters enormously. But giving a child access to answers is not the same as building a mind that

knows what to do with them. The AI industry has very little incentive to explain that difference.

Before AI came
Reading was already in trouble before AI arrived. For years, schools had quietly replaced sustained engagement with complex texts with excerpts, summaries and test-friendly passages that asked students to identify the main idea rather than live inside one. A study of English major students in the U.S. found that only five in 100 could correctly interpret a passage from Dickens. AI did not start this crisis. It arrived into one already in motion and handed an entire generation the perfect reason to stop trying.

What reading does to a young mind is not well understood even by people who love books. Children cannot comprehend what they read if they lack the background knowledge that texts quietly assume. That



Before the shortcut

Why students need to read before they use AI

knowledge does not come from a summary or a chatbot. It comes from reading itself, from thousands of hours of genuine

encounter with language, ideas, characters and arguments, built slowly, year by year. You cannot shortcut the infrastruc-

ture. When you try, you get students who can produce a paragraph about a story they never actually read. Everyone will call it education.

Teachers already know this. Thirty assignments arrive on their desks, fluent and identical in tone from students who cannot explain

their own work when asked to do so. The thinking simply never happened. A 2025 Microsoft study reviewed by the Brookings Institute across 400 global research papers found that heavy AI use was measurably linked to weaker critical thinking and independent judgement. This is not simply a technology problem. Schools adopted the tools before they built the habits that would make those tools safe to use.

Way forward
The AI industry will not fix this on its own. Frictionless access to information is the product. That productive struggle is essential to learning does not appear in any roadmap or school adoption pitch. That conversation has to begin inside schools, inside homes, at kitchen tables, in classrooms where a teacher decides that reading is not optional, not today, not on her watch.

The schools getting this right are not doing anything complicated. Reading gets a protected period each day, treated with the same institu-

tional seriousness as Maths. Assignments ask students to connect a text to their own experience, to disagree with it in their own voice, to produce something that cannot be photographed and fed into a machine. The text comes first. Every single time. Any tool, if it enters at all, enters only after the student has already thought.

A student who reads deeply and then uses AI arrives at a place that neither the book nor the machine could have taken her. She brings knowledge to the tool and questions the output because she has enough of her own thinking to notice when something is wrong. Reading gives her a spine. AI gives her reach. Without the first, the second is simply a very confident way of knowing nothing at all.

The library shelves are still full. The decision to build a child's mind before handing her a shortcut is still available. But it will not wait for us indefinitely.

The writer is Assistant Professor, School of Holistic Development, MIT-ADT University, Pune.

The start-up campus

How incubators can redefine the role of universities in India

Ojasvi Babber

For decades, Indian universities operated within a well-defined boundary: teach, examine, certify. The relationship between student and institution was largely transactional, measured in credits earned and placements secured. That model is no longer sufficient. According to data from DPIIT, Government of India, in April 2026, the country now has over 2.23 lakh DPIIT-recognised startups as of March 2026, with more than 55,200 recognised in FY 2025-26 alone. These ventures have collectively generated over 23.36 lakh direct jobs. Behind those numbers is a structural shift worth examining: universities, through their incubators, are increasingly producing ventures and founders, not just graduates.

Labs to launchpads
What makes university-based incubation distinct from commercial accelerators is proximity to research infrastructure, faculty expertise, and a peer group that is still learning. A student working on an AI-driven battery management system can access materials science labs, engineering faculty, and a cohort solving adjacent problems within the same institution. This density of capability is difficult to replicate outside a campus.

The zero-to-one stage – moving from an unformed idea to a working proof of concept – is where most start-ups fail. University incubators can support this

stage because they can absorb ambiguity in ways market-driven programmes cannot by allowing a student-founder to iterate and pivot without the immediate pressure of investor expectations. This does not mean indefinite shelter. The best university incubators build structured pathways: from ideation workshops and design thinking to formal incubation with mentorship, funding access, and industry linkages.

Investments
India's government has invested significantly in university-led innovation infrastructure. The Startup India Seed Fund Scheme has committed ₹945 crore across 219 incubators, channelling over ₹605 crore to more than 3,400 startups. The Atal Innovation Mission has operationalised 72 incubation centres that have nurtured over 6,782 start-ups and generated more than 32,000 jobs AIM Parliament data, March 2026). MeitY's TIDE 2.0 programme empowers over 51 incubators to support nearly 2,000 tech startups in healthcare, education, agriculture, and clean energy.

Over 7,265 Institution Innovation Councils now operate across 28 states under the Ministry of Education, creating structured ecosystems for ideation and pre-incubation within campuses.

The National Education Policy (NEP) 2020 formalises all of this. It directs higher education institutions to establish incubation centres and technology development hubs, introduces the

"Professor of Practice" framework to bring industry expertise into classrooms, and envisions institutions functioning as innovation hubs by 2030. This is a coherent policy stack. But challenges persist.

Gaps
First, incubation quality remains uneven. Leading institutions run incubators with strong industry linkages. Many tier-2-and-3 universities still treat incubation as a compliance exercise rather than a strategic function. Second, success metrics remain narrow. Counting startups incubated or patents filed tells only part of the story. Whether the incubation experience changes how students approach problems and risk is harder to measure but more important. Third, the bridge between university-incubated ventures and the venture capital ecosystem remains under construction. Structured demo days, corporate innovation partnerships, and campus-linked angel networks can improve the transition from campus to market.

The entrepreneurial energy exists, as does the policy infrastructure. The university of the future will not be defined solely by the knowledge it transmits, but by the ventures it enables and the entrepreneurs it launches. For institutions willing to embrace that expanded mandate, the opportunity is significant. For those that resist, the risk of irrelevance grows each year.

The writer is CEO, Amity Innovation Incubator.



THINK
Aruna Sankaranarayanan

For the last couple of years, I have been maintaining a reading log. Nothing fancy, just a list of books I complete each month. Like most people nowadays, I don't read as much as I would like to. Though I try to read every day, I feel I should read a lot more. Keeping a log not only serves as a reminder of the books I've read, but it also motivates me to keep reading. Browsing my reading list, I noticed that I had read two massive tomes in the past six months. What was particularly striking was the quality of attention that each one demanded.

Differing novels

The first was the novel, *The Loneliness of Sonia and Sunny*, by Kiran Desai. From the word go, this book pulled me in like a magnet. I breezed through its pages, which were pacy yet rich with descriptive detail. As the characters zigzagged across countries and continents, my attentive gaze shadowed them.

In contrast, I initially struggled to get through *Middlemarch* by George Eliot. Interestingly, psy-



Willingness to wait

Why the quality of cognitive patience is important

chologist Maryanne Wolf notes in *Reader, Come Home* that she too found it difficult to plough through this book. Like Wolf, I had also read *Middlemarch* in my younger days when digital devices didn't exist and it was not uncommon for people to read uninterrupted for long periods of time. But this time was different and I couldn't help comparing it with my experience of reading Desai's book.

The *Loneliness of Sonia and Sunny* is set mainly in India and the United States, two countries that I know intimately and at a

time, the 1990s, when I too came of age. I relate to the protagonists and their worldviews. Further, the novel crisscrosses many cities – Allahabad, New Delhi, Goa, Vermont, New York and Venice – giving momentum to the book, literally and figuratively, as the protagonists trace different arcs. On the other hand, *Middlemarch* is set in a fictional English town in the 1830s, a historical period that feels remote and unfamiliar to me. Further, the book revolves around a single town and lacks the momentum that characterises Desai's novel.

Staying on course
But something made me stick with it. As I plodded on, the book gradually grew on me like a vine that initially creeps upwards but gradually covers an entire wall. By the time I was midway through the book, I was sufficiently enmeshed in the characters' lives that I had to find out how their individual trajectories unfolded. Though I had read the book earlier, I didn't remember the plot or subplots and the book ended up holding me in its grip.

However, if I hadn't persisted through the early

pages, I would have been robbed of this penetrating study of human nature. Despite inhabiting a different cultural and historical period, the characters are very relatable as they navigate marriage, ambition, social hierarchies and familial dynamics. To mine the riches this book had to offer, I had to cultivate delayed gratification.

It is this quality of attention – the slow-to-form variety – that is practically being erased from human experience. Perhaps it's not just attention but also cognitive patience, a willingness to allow a world to unfold before us. Not at a frenetic pace or even one that we control or decide upon.

As we are surfeited with a glut of information, our attention has become scattered, shallow and fragmented. In fact, Wolf asks a poignant question: what will happen if the "language of books" doesn't align with the "culture's cognitive style"? This loss is not limited to what we glean from books. An ability to wait and watch, to observe patterns as they unfold and to stay the course when the going gets tough are endemic facets of a reflective and resilient life.

The writer is visiting faculty at the School of Education, Azim Premji University, Bengaluru, and the co-author of Bee-Witched.

Can India keep its cool?

Why climate education must begin with real-world challenges like rising AC demand

Pranav Chopra

Picture this: you walk into an exam hall in May; it is 44°C outside. The ceiling fans are spinning but the room is stifling. You find it hard to concentrate. Now imagine this becoming the norm for every classroom, every office, every home across India for months at a time. This is a not-so-distant possibility. It is already happening. As temperatures rise, power grids are under strain and the very systems we use to escape the heat – air conditioners – are making the problem worse. For students at the threshold of building India's future, understanding this paradox is not optional; it is urgent.

Rising demand

India's cooling demand is expected to grow eightfold by 2037-38. As temperatures climb, more homes, schools, hospitals, and workplaces will need air conditioning. But here is the catch: most of today's



ACs run on coal-powered electricity and use refrigerants that are potent greenhouse gases.

So, the more we cool ourselves, the more we heat the planet. The more we heat the planet, the more we need cooling. This feedback loop is one of the defining engineering challenges today, and does not have a simple fix. It requires people who can think across disciplines, who understand both the physics of heat transfer and the economics of ener-

gy, the chemistry of refrigerants and the design of cities. How does this change how today's students study?

Often, Environmental Science in school is treated as a subject to score marks, not one that shapes how you think about everything else. Consider what climate-aware thinking looks like across subjects. A student who understands thermodynamics and the urban heat island effect will design buildings differently. One who grasps da-

ta structures and energy efficiency will write software that does not needlessly drain power from already-stressed grids. A student who connects economics with resource scarcity will approach business problems with questions that most others are not even asking yet. Climate literacy does not narrow your thinking. It deepens it.

Economic opportunity
Here is what is often left out of the conversation: climate challenges are also among the largest economic opportunities of this decade. Government programmes are investing heavily in clean energy and efficient cooling. Start-ups building green cooling solutions, solar infrastructure, EV charging networks, and water-efficient systems are attracting serious capital. These are commercially viable businesses solving real problems at scale.

Students already exploring this space are not waiting for the curriculum to catch up. Teams from IIT-Bombay have demonstrated near-zero energy building designs. Competitions like the SDI Challenge are producing innovations in thermal efficiency. Across the country, young people are building low-cost air

quality monitors, smart energy systems, and materials that reduce heat absorption in buildings. Most of them are figuring it out through competitions and personal curiosity, not because their institutions pointed them here. That gap is a missed opportunity.

How can you get involved? You do not need a specialised programme. Begin by asking a different kind of question. When you study thermodynamics, ask what it means to design buildings in a 45°C city. When you study economics, ask how a country prices carbon or subsidises clean energy. When you learn to code, find out the energy cost of your programme at scale.

The students who will define India's next chapter are not waiting for someone to hand them the syllabus. They are the ones who have already understood that the most important design problems of the coming decades are not hypothetical; they are playing out right now, every summer, across a country that is getting hotter. The question is whether you will be ready to solve them.

The author is co-founder and CTO of Optimist.



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